



## Sant' Apollinare in Classe

Location Ravenna, Italy

The 6th-century Sant' Apollinare in Classe is among the first mature early Christian basilicas, consisting of a nave, aisles to either side, and an apse at its east end. The 183-ft- (56-m-) high nave is exactly twice the height of the aisles and is separated from them by 24 huge columns. However, the true glory of the building is one of the most characteristic forms of Byzantine-influenced church decoration: the shimmering mosaics of the apse. Predominantly gold, green, and blue, they follow a complex iconographical scheme, celebrating not just the divinity of Christ but also of the 1st-century CE martyr St. Apollinaris. He is shown calling his flock of 12 sheep—a reference to the Apostles—against a vivid, flower-strewn landscape.

## Skellig Michael

Location County Kerry, Ireland

Skellig Michael is a bleak and rocky island that rises steeply from the Atlantic 7 miles (12km) off the southwest coast of Ireland. From around the early 6th century CE to about 1200, it was the site of a tiny Augustinian monastery. The monks lived in six dry-stone beehive cells. These austere structures have survived, as have the monastery's two tiny stone-built chapels, both of which resemble upturned boats. The larger of the two measures just 14 ft (4.3m) long and 12 ft (3.6m) wide. The site also includes a similarly diminutive cemetery and the remains of a kitchen garden. Upward of 100 gaunt stone crosses are studded across the island. As Rome collapsed, it was in such remote places that Christian learning clung to survival in northern Europe.

◀ MONASTIC BEEHIVE HUTS ON THE ISLAND OF SKELLIG MICHAEL